THE ROLE EVERY ENGINEER IS TALKING ABOUT

How to be a Forward Deployed Engineer

...and why you should care

Alec Harrison

Staff AI Engineer · Microsoft MVP (AI) · Microsoft Certified Trainer

WHO'S TALKING

A quick word on me

- Staff AI Engineer at LeanTECHniques
- Microsoft MVP (AI) & Microsoft Certified Trainer
- I ship production RAG, agent workflows, MCP integrations and Azure AI Foundry solutions
- LinkedIn Learning instructor (Azure AI-102)

I LEAD AZURE USER GROUPS

4,000+

engineers reached across communities in Iowa, Omaha & Kansas City

THE TREND

A niche title just became one of the hottest jobs in tech

“Forward Deployed Engineer” used to live almost entirely inside Palantir. Now it's a headline role at AI-first companies everywhere — and demand is outrunning supply.

WHAT I'VE SEEN THESE ROLES PAY

~$140K avg

…and often $140–180K+ as you move up

Anecdotal — this is the pay I keep seeing in the field, not a formal survey.

DEFINITION

So what actually is an FDE?

An engineer who embeds with the customer, digs up the real problem, and ships working software right inside the customer's environment.

Part engineer

You build. Real, production software — not slideware or demos.

Part consultant

You sit with the customer, run discovery, and earn trust.

Part product

You decide what's worth building and own the outcome, not the ticket.

MY TAKE

What being an FDE means to me

I turn “AI is cool” into “AI made us money”

The job is impact you can point to, not novelty.

I sit next to the problem — not three teams away

Proximity to the customer is the whole advantage.

I own outcomes, not tickets

Nobody hands me a spec. I go find what's actually worth doing.

THE CASE

Why you should care

1

Life-changing money

Strong comp, and it climbs fast as you prove you can deliver.

2

Career-proofing

In the AI era, adaptable beats complacent. This role forces you to stay sharp.

3

Impact + access

You're in the room where decisions get made — not downstream of them.

THE PATH

How I think about the journey

Five phases I use to take someone from curious to shipping in production.

1	2	3	4	5
Mindset	**Technical foundations**	**Product & discovery**	**Embed with customers**	**Ship & productize**
Stay adaptable	Learn the stack	Find the real problem	Build where it lives	Make it safe & real

TIP 1 · MINDSET

01

Never stop learning

AI innovation moves faster than any single skill you have today. The people who thrive treat learning as the job, not a side quest. Your edge isn't what you already know — it's how fast you re-tool when the ground shifts.

THE RISK

In this field, complacency is the career risk.

Staying adaptable is non-negotiable.

TIP 2 · PRODUCT & DISCOVERY

02

Ask the magic wand question

The fastest way to find work worth doing: get people to tell you what they hate. My go-to prompt uncovers the pain they've stopped even complaining about — the stuff that's ripe for automation.

MY FAVORITE QUESTION

“If you could wave a magic wand and never do one part of your job again — what would you wish away?”

TIP 3 · PRIORITIZATION

03

Follow the money

You'll always have more ideas than time. The tiebreaker is simple and it keeps you employed: anchor every project to the business, not the tech.

THE ONLY TWO QUESTIONS

Does it MAKE the company money?

Does it SAVE the company money?

If you can't tie it to one of those, it's a hobby — not a priority.

TIP 4 · EMBEDDING WITH CUSTOMERS

04

Build inside the customer's house

“If you build it, they will come” is a trap. Build inside the customer's own environment so their team can actually maintain it after you leave — and resist over-engineering for reuse that never materializes.

WATCH OUT FOR

Don't build a beautiful platform nobody adopts.

Build where the work already happens.

TIP 5 · SHIPPING & PRODUCTIZING

05

Ship it — safely

Getting to production is where the value is realized, but it's also where the risk lives. Guardrails and content safety come before go-live, and evaluation plus observability are how you earn the right to trust the system.

EARN AUTONOMY

Start human-in-the-loop.

Move to fully autonomous only once it's proven safe to let the model run.

YOUR MOVE

How to get started — this month

1

Pick one real problem

At your current job. Run the magic-wand question on a coworker this week.

2

Ship one thing end-to-end

Infuse AI into a single existing workflow. Small and done beats big and someday.

3

Learn fundamentals first

Cloud-agnostic basics, then go deep on one platform. I lean Azure / Microsoft Foundry.

4

Get reps with people

Practice discovery and stakeholder conversations — not just code.

PLAY THE LONG GAME

Invest in yourself

- Build in public and join a community — user groups are rocket fuel
- Fundamentals first, then one cloud deep (e.g. Azure AI-102)
- Practice discovery as deliberately as you practice coding

THE REALITY

Most FDE work isn't greenfield AI.

It's infusing inference into systems, apps and procedures that already exist. That's not less exciting — it's where the real leverage is.

WHERE TO GO FROM HERE

The field is growing fast — and there's room for you.

Start where you are. Ship something small. Go talk to a customer.

Thank you — let's talk

Alec Harrison · Find me at your local Azure user group & on LinkedIn